

CBS Field Guide

Quick Guide for Community-Based Surveillance

Purpose: Community-Based Surveillance (CBS) helps communities act as the eyes and ears of the health system. It helps find unusual illness or deaths early so they can be reported quickly to health authorities.

CBS is used to detect signals, not to diagnose diseases.

1. Possible CBS Signals

A **signal** is an unusual health event that may mean there is a public health problem. Examples include:

- Two or more people with similar severe illness in the same community within one week
- Many people with severe diarrhea or vomiting
- Sudden or unexplained deaths
- Fever with rash
- An illness the community has not seen before
- Many animals dying suddenly
- Any health event that worries the community

Signals may vary by country according to national guidelines.

2. Key Information to Gather and Report

When you hear about a possible signal, try to learn and report:

Question	Details
Who is sick?	Names, ages, households
What symptoms do they have?	Specific signs and complaints
When did the illness start?	Date of onset for each case
Where are the sick people located?	Village, area, neighborhood
How many people are sick?	Count of known cases
How severe is the illness?	Mild, moderate, severe, deaths
Shared exposures?	Food, water, travel, or gatherings

Report brief but important information. Health authorities will investigate in more detail later.

3. What To Do When You Detect a Signal

1. Gather basic information.
2. Write it in your notebook or reporting form.
3. Report the signal immediately to your supervisor.
4. Follow instructions from supervisors or health staff.
5. **Do not wait** for the next meeting if the signal may be serious.

Example Signal Report:

“This is Fatou, CHV in Village A. Since Friday, I have seen about 5 people with severe watery diarrhoea and vomiting in the lower part of Village A and nearby Village C. Some are very weak. They use the same open well near the river.”

4. Community Informants

Important people who may notice illness early include:

- Market vendors
- Religious leaders
- Teachers
- Traditional healers
- Livestock owners
- Community leaders

They can help you learn about unusual illness or deaths.

5. Role of the Supervisor

Supervisors should:

- Review signals reported by CHWs
- Check (verify) signals within 24 hours when possible
- Record signals in the Signal Register
- Report confirmed events to district health authorities
- Support and give feedback to CHWs

Key Principle

If you are not sure, report the signal. Early reporting helps protect the community.